

FREE STARTER GUIDE

# Your QA orientation

A practical starting point for learning how quality assurance supports people, products, and delivery teams.

**Start here**

QA is not just finding bugs at the end. It is the habit of reducing avoidable surprises by asking better questions throughout the work.

## What QA is

Quality assurance helps a team understand whether a product works as intended for the people who rely on it. Good QA brings curiosity, product context, risk awareness, and clear communication to every stage of delivery.

- **Quality assurance:** preventing avoidable problems by improving the way work is planned, built, tested, and learned from.
- **Testing:** checking behavior to learn whether the product meets expectations and where risk remains.
- **Quality control:** activities that identify defects or gaps in the finished work.

## Five terms to know

**Test case**

A documented set of conditions and steps used to check an expected behavior.

**Defect**

A difference between expected behavior and what the product actually does.

**Regression**

A check that existing behavior still works after a change.

**Risk** The likelihood and impact of something going wrong for users, the business, or delivery.

**Accessibility** Designing and testing so people with different abilities can use a product successfully.

## A practical 30-day starting plan

**Week 1 - Learn the language** Read QA terms, practice writing expected versus actual behavior, and observe how a familiar app handles errors, empty states, and navigation.

**Week 2 - Practice test design** Choose one small feature. List the happy path, a few ways it could fail, boundary conditions, and questions you would ask before testing.

**Week 3 - Explore with purpose** Use a short charter such as: explore account creation for new users using only a keyboard. Capture what you learn and why it matters.

**Week 4 - Build a small proof of work** Write a bug report, a mini test plan, or one readable automated check for a stable workflow. Explain your choices and what risk they address.

## Tools to explore

- Browser developer tools for inspecting behavior, network requests, and responsive layouts.
- A test management or note-taking tool for organizing questions, scenarios, and findings.
- An API client for learning how systems exchange data and handle failure responses.
- An automation framework such as Playwright when you are ready to practice repeatable checks.

## Practice ideas

- Test a sign-in, search, checkout, or profile-update flow in an app you know well.
- Write three clear defects: title, steps, expected behavior, actual behavior, environment, and impact.

- Run a keyboard-only pass and record where focus, labels, or messages make the experience harder to use.

## Career and certification context

There is no single route into QA. People enter from customer support, development, business analysis, design, and many other backgrounds. The strongest evidence of growth is a combination of practice, communication, product understanding, and a willingness to keep learning.

### **Certifications**

A foundation-testing credential can provide structure and shared terminology. Treat it as optional evidence of learning, not a replacement for hands-on practice or a guarantee of employment.

## Your next useful step

- Use the it's watt Knowledge Base when a QA term is unfamiliar.
- Choose the Beginner, Intermediate, or Advanced route that best fits your current experience.
- Try the QA Toolkits to decide what to automate or generate test ideas from a user story.

Keep learning in public. Test with purpose.